IR Exam Case Bank

> **How to use.** For any question, pick ONE theory as your main answer and ONE as your rebutted counter. Each row = that theory's angle, the **named concepts** to use (all from the course/notes), two empirical examples, and the weakness to expect in the counterargument. ⚠️ = forced fit (that theory struggles here; good to know for picking a *counter*, risky as a *main*).
>
> **5 theories:** Realism (structural) · Liberal institutionalism · Liberal internationalism · Constructivism · Critical theory. Examples are *named only* — flesh out the identity/mechanism story yourself in the essay.
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> **The named concepts per theory (use only these):**
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> - **Realism:** anarchy · self-help · security dilemma · balance of power · relative vs absolute gains · polarity · power transition · deterrence · bandwagoning.
> - **Lib. institutionalism:** absolute gains · institutions · international regime (Krasner) · the 4 mechanisms (*shadow of the future · information/monitoring · reciprocity/enforcement · interdependence*) · complex interdependence (sensitivity/vulnerability) · collective security.
> - **Lib. internationalism:** Kantian triangle (democracy + interdependence + IOs) · democratic peace · domestic preferences / opening the black box.
> - **Constructivism:** identity · norms · logic of appropriateness (vs logic of consequences) · social construction · intersubjective meaning (social vs material facts) · "anarchy is what states make of it" · socialisation.
> - **Critical theory:** hegemony (Gramsci) · class / Marxism · world-systems (core–periphery, Wallerstein) · ideology / legitimation · postcolonialism.

★ The core 20 — memorise THESE, reuse everywhere

Learn these 20 instead of 75. Each has the **facts you'd actually cite** + how to **frame the same event through each theory** it serves. *Fits Q* = question numbers it works for.

1. US–USSR Cold War (1947–91). *Fits Q6, 10, 11, 12.* Bipolar nuclear rivalry — arms race and proxy wars, then détente and arms-control treaties (SALT, INF). • *Realism:* security dilemma + balance of power + deterrence (MAD) → intense rivalry but no direct war. • *Lib. inst.:* SALT/INF = institutions letting rivals cooperate on the one issue that matters. • *Constr.:* the two *constructed* each other as existential enemies — enmity, not just material capability.

2. Cuban Missile Crisis (1962). *Fits Q10, 12.* USSR put missiles in Cuba; 13-day standoff; resolved by USSR withdrawing them and US secretly pulling missiles from Turkey + pledging not to invade Cuba. • *Realism:* brinkmanship under the shadow of nuclear war; relative power. • *Two-level games:* each leader had to sell the deal to hardliners at home — the secret Turkey swap shows domestic ratification constraints.

3. NATO (1949–). *Fits Q4, 7, 8.* Collective-defence alliance formed to balance the USSR — and it *survived* the USSR's collapse, enlarging eastward. • *Realism:* balancing a threat (but its post-1991 survival is realism's embarrassment). • *Lib. inst.:* an enduring institution lowering cooperation costs. • *Constr.:* a transatlantic "security community" bound by shared democratic identity, not just threat.

4. The EU (1951–). *Fits Q4, 7, 10, 12.* Deep economic + political integration that made war between France and Germany "unthinkable." • *Lib. inst.:* complex interdependence + institutions make war too costly. • *Lib. intl.:* a club of democracies (democratic peace). • *Constr.:* built a partial European identity / security community.

5. NPT (1968). *Fits Q2, 5, 8, 11.* Non-proliferation regime: non-nuclear states pledge not to build; the five nuclear "haves" are recognised as exceptions and pledge (vaguely) to disarm. • *Lib. inst.:* a regime raising the cost of proliferating → most states don't. • *Critical:* a two-tier order — the powerful keep bombs, the rest give them up.

6. Kazakhstan / Ukraine denuclearisation (Budapest Memorandum, 1994). *Fits Q2, 11.* Both inherited huge Soviet arsenals and gave them up for security assurances + NPT membership. • *Lib. inst.:* institutions (NPT + assurances) made giving up the capability safe. • *Realism:* they couldn't afford/secure the arsenal and took a great-power guarantee — which 2022 showed was hollow.

7. Brazil–Argentina (ABACC, 1991). *Fits Q2, 15.* Two rivals, both with secret nuclear programmes, democratised and built a *joint mutual-inspection agency* instead of bombs. • *Lib. inst.:* reciprocity + verification let rivals disarm without either being exposed. • *Lib. intl.:* democratisation changed the domestic preference. • Kills critical theory's "strong coerce weak" line — these were *equals*.

8. US–China today. *Fits Q1, 5, 15.* A rising power challenging the incumbent: deep trade ties *and* rivalry over Taiwan, tech, the South China Sea. • *Realism:* power transition + relative gains. • *Lib. inst.:* interdependence/WTO restrain conflict. • *Constr.:* whether they're "rivals" depends on threat framing.

9. Russia–Ukraine / Crimea (2014, 2022). *Fits Q1, 3, 14.* Russia — a UN founding power that helped make sovereignty sacrosanct — annexed Crimea and invaded Ukraine; hit by sweeping sanctions. • *Realism:* balancing NATO enlargement; sphere of influence. • *Constr.:* "Russian world" identity — Ukraine as *part of* Russia's self-conception. • *Critical:* a great power rewriting rules it authored. • *Q14:* sanctions largely failed (survival + Chinese help).

10. US–Iraq 2003. *Fits Q3, 5, 9.* The US invaded without UN Security Council authorisation — ignoring the Charter it helped write. • *Realism:* it had the power to. • *Constr.:* American *exceptionalism* — identity as the indispensable nation above the rules. • *Critical:* "humanitarian/WMD" cover for hegemonic/resource interests.

11. WWI / 1914. *Fits Q6, 10, 11, 12.* A rising Germany, rigid alliances, and an arms race ended in catastrophic war — *despite* dense pre-war trade. • *Realism:* power transition + security dilemma. • *Liberalism's own weakness:* interdependence did **not** prevent war (use this to rebut liberalism). • *Critical:* imperial/capitalist rivalry.

12. WTO / global trade regime. *Fits Q5, 8, 15.* The institution that built rules-based trade — which the US, its chief architect, later undercut (tariffs, paralysing the appellate body). • *Lib. inst.:* reputation + reciprocity → mostly obeyed. • *Realism:* the powerful follow rules only while convenient.

13. UN Security Council veto. *Fits Q3, 5, 8.* The five victors of WWII gave *themselves* a permanent veto. • *Critical:* an institution literally built to serve the great powers ("who wrote the rules?"). • *Realism:* institutions mirror the distribution of power.

14. Democratic peace (W. Europe post-1945). *Fits Q4, 10, 12.* No two mature democracies have fought a full-scale war; former enemies (France–Germany) became close partners. • *Lib. intl.:* Kantian triangle — accountability, interdependence, IOs. • *Realist counter:* it was shared interests + the US alliance, not democracy.

15. Rwanda 1994 vs Somalia 1992 / Libya 2011. *Fits Q9.* The world did *not* intervene in the Rwandan genocide but *did* in Somalia and Libya. • *Constr.:* widening (and selective) norms of who "deserves" protection. • *Realism:* intervention tracks strategic interest — Rwanda had none.

16. Iran nuclear deal / JCPOA (2015). *Fits Q5, 14.* Iran capped its programme for sanctions relief; the US later withdrew (2018). • *Lib. inst.:* an institution/regime trading verification for relief. • *Two-level games:* the US ratification fight (and withdrawal) shows Level-II domestic politics undoing a Level-I deal.

17. North Korea. *Fits Q5, 11, 14.* Built nuclear weapons for regime survival, *left* the NPT (2003), and has absorbed years of sanctions. • *Realism:* self-help + deterrence for survival under anarchy. • *Q14:* sanctions failed — survival trumps economic pain.

18. South Africa. *Fits Q2.* The only state to *build* nuclear weapons and then voluntarily *dismantle* them (c. 1989–91), joining the NPT as apartheid ended. • *Lib. intl.:* a new domestic regime changed the preference. • *Constr.:* a new post-apartheid identity made the bomb inappropriate.

19. China & the South China Sea (2016 ruling). *Fits Q3, 5, 15.* China ratified the Law of the Sea, then ignored the 2016 tribunal ruling against its claims. • *Realism:* a rising power defies law when strong enough. • *Critical:* the order's rules bind the weak, not the powerful.

20. Trump "America First" (2017–). *Fits Q3, 13.* Withdrawals (Paris, JCPOA, WHO) and tariffs driven by domestic politics. • *Lib. intl. / FPA / two-level games:* domestic coalitions and leaders — not the system — drove the rule-breaking. • Good for "why states act against the systemic 'national interest'."

Under pressure: pick the question → grab 2 examples whose *Fits Q* includes it → tell each one's facts, then frame through your theory. Two of these, done well, answer almost any question.

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1. Why do rival states cooperate in one area while staying hostile in another?

Theory	Explanation (1-line)	Concepts (named)	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Cooperate where it doesn't shift the relative balance; hostile where it does	relative vs absolute gains, balance of power, self-help	Russia–EU gas (vs NATO); India–China trade (vs border)	Struggles to explain *durable, institutionalised* cooperation
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions make cooperation safe in one domain	institutions, international regime, reciprocity	US–USSR arms control; US–China climate talks amid trade war	Can't explain persisting hostility
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic preferences favour cooperation on some issues, not others	domestic preferences, the black box	US–China (business lobby vs security hawks)	Thin on *why rivalry persists*; forced
Constructivism	Different shared meanings/identities built per issue-area	identity, intersubjective meaning, "anarchy is what states make of it"	US–China (partner vs rival framing)	Weak at predicting *which* area turns cooperative
Critical theory	Cooperation serves dominant economic interests; hostility masks it	hegemony, class, world-systems	Russia–EU energy capital; Gulf states–West	Hard to test; over-reads everything as capital

2. Why do some states abandon a military capability they've already developed?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Abandon when a guarantee/alliance covers the need, or coerced	deterrence, balance of power, self-help	Kazakhstan/Ukraine (assurances); Germany/Japan post-45	Distrusts institutions — awkward with voluntary treaty disarmament
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions make verified mutual disarmament safe	reciprocity/enforcement, information/monitoring, international regime	Brazil–Argentina (ABACC); Kazakhstan (NPT)	Can't explain defection (North Korea leaving NPT)
Lib. internationalism	A new domestic coalition (democratisation) drops the programme	domestic preferences, the black box, democratic peace	Brazil & Argentina (post-dictatorship); South Africa	Needs a domestic shift — silent when there isn't one
Constructivism	A norm (non-proliferation) reshapes identity	norms, socialisation, logic of appropriateness	nuclear taboo; South Africa's post-apartheid identity	Weak where disarmament is clearly coerced
Critical theory	The strong pressure the weak to disarm while keeping their own	hegemony, world-systems (core–periphery)	NPT haves/have-nots; Libya/Iraq WMD disarmament	Can't explain equal-power mutual disarmament (Brazil–Argentina)

3. Why are great powers more likely than small states to break rules they helped create?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Relative power lets them ignore rules; small states can't	relative gains, self-help, polarity	US–Iraq 2003; Russia–Crimea/Ukraine	Can't explain why great powers *ever* obey
Lib. institutionalism	Great powers depend on institutions less, so the costs bite less	complex interdependence (vulnerability), reciprocity	US tariffs/WTO; US & ICC	Under-predicts how often great powers *do* comply
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic politics (nationalism, executives) push rule-breaking	domestic preferences, the black box	Trump "America First"; Brexit	Doesn't track the *great/small* split cleanly; forced
Constructivism	Great powers' identity = exceptional/above the rules they authored	identity, logic of appropriateness	US exceptionalism (Iraq, ICC); Russia's great-power self-image	Must show identity, not just the act (reads as realism)
Critical theory	The order is built to serve the powerful; "rules" bind only the weak	hegemony, ideology/legitimation	UNSC veto; US & ICC exemption	Hard to falsify

4. Why do democracies rarely fight each other?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	Not democracy — shared interests, alliances, Cold War structure	balance of power, polarity	NATO democracies vs USSR; US–UK alliance	Denies a robust empirical finding; defensive
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions + interdependence make war too costly	complex interdependence, institutions, absolute gains	EU members; Bretton Woods order	Doesn't explain the *democracy-specific* pattern
Lib. internationalism	Accountability, public opinion restrain war between republics	Kantian triangle, democratic peace	no two mature democracies fought (20th c.); EU	"Democracy" is contested; edge-case wars exist
Constructivism	Democracies share an in-group identity — war feels inappropriate	identity, norms, logic of appropriateness	transatlantic community; EU "security community"	Hard to measure "identity"; risks circularity
Critical theory ⚠️	"Democratic peace" masks shared capitalist-class interest	class, hegemony, ideology	Western bloc cohesion; global capital order	Strains against the clean empirical record

5. Why do states comply with international law no one can enforce?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when it serves interests / the powerful want it	self-help, balance of power	UNCLOS when convenient; great-power selectivity	Can't explain costly compliance
Lib. institutionalism	Reputation + reciprocity + shadow of the future make it pay	reciprocity/enforcement, shadow of the future, international regime	WTO rulings mostly obeyed; trade law	Weak vs great-power defection
Lib. internationalism	Domestic courts/groups internalise and demand compliance	domestic preferences, the black box	ECHR in domestic courts; EU law	Varies hugely by regime type
Constructivism	Law is internalised as "appropriate"	norms, logic of appropriateness, socialisation	decolonisation norm; torture taboo	Can't explain brazen violations
Critical theory	Law legitimises the powerful; compliance = consent to hegemony	hegemony, ideology/legitimation	investment/trade law favouring the core	Over-reads; hard to test

6. Why do arms races happen?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Defensive build-ups look offensive under anarchy	security dilemma, self-help, relative gains	US–USSR Cold War; pre-1914 naval race	Can't explain restraint/de-escalation
Lib. institutionalism	Failure of institutions to provide information/reassurance	information/monitoring, international regime	arms-control treaties that *stopped* races (INF)	Explains the *fix* better than the *race*
Lib. internationalism	Domestic lobbies (military-industrial) drive it	domestic preferences, the black box	US defence lobby; Cold War procurement	Needs a specific domestic driver
Constructivism ⚠️	Rival identities make the other's arms seem threatening	identity, intersubjective meaning (social vs material)	India–Pakistan rivalry; US–USSR enmity	Thin on *why build-ups spiral*
Critical theory	Arms racing serves capital/the militarist order	class, hegemony	arms-industry profits; Cold War economy	Hard to falsify

7. Why do states form alliances?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Balance against a greater threat (or bandwagon with it)	balance of power, bandwagoning, polarity	NATO vs USSR; anti-Napoleon coalitions	Struggles with alliance *persistence* after threat ends (NATO post-91)
Lib. institutionalism	Alliances as institutions lowering cooperation costs	institutions, reciprocity, collective security	NATO's enduring structure; EU defence	Under-weights raw threat
Lib. internationalism	Shared regime type / domestic affinity	democratic peace, domestic preferences	NATO democracies; US–UK	Doesn't explain alliances *with* autocracies
Constructivism	Shared identity/community, not just threat	identity, "security community"	transatlantic community; ASEAN	Weak when alliances are purely instrumental
Critical theory	Alliances entrench the hegemon's order	hegemony, world-systems	US alliance system; client states	Over-reads; hard to test

8. Why do international institutions persist even when they can't compel states?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	They persist only while they serve the powerful	self-help, balance of power	UNSC veto; IMF weighted votes	Can't explain institutions outliving the founder's interest
Lib. institutionalism	They lower transaction costs, solve collective-action problems	institutions, international regime, shadow of the future	WTO; WHO; UN system	Over-optimistic vs great-power sidelining
Lib. internationalism	Domestic groups benefit and lobby to keep them	domestic preferences, the black box	EU constituencies; trade lobbies	Varies by state
Constructivism	They become taken-for-granted, part of "normal" order	norms, socialisation, intersubjective meaning	the UN's legitimacy; sovereignty norm	Can't explain sudden collapses
Critical theory	They reproduce the hegemonic order and look "natural"	hegemony (Gramsci), ideology/legitimation	IMF/World Bank conditionality; Bretton Woods	Hard to falsify

9. Why do states (sometimes) intervene in humanitarian crises?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when strategic interests coincide	self-help, balance of power	Libya 2011 (interest-aligned); Rwanda 1994 (non-intervention)	Can't explain genuinely costly intervention
Lib. institutionalism	Collective action via IOs/authorisation	collective security, institutions	UN-authorised missions; R2P	Weak when IOs are paralysed
Lib. internationalism	Public opinion/domestic pressure drives it	democratic peace, domestic preferences	"CNN effect"; democratic publics	Inconsistent across cases
Constructivism	Widening norms of who "deserves" protection	norms, logic of appropriateness, socialisation	Somalia 1992; R2P norm emergence	Can't explain non-intervention (Rwanda)
Critical theory	"Humanitarian" cover for hegemonic/economic interests	hegemony, postcolonialism, ideology	Iraq/Libya resource angle	Cynical; hard to test

10. Why do some rivalries end in war while others stay peaceful?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Power shifts / security dilemma tip rivalry into war	power transition, security dilemma	WWI (rising Germany); US–USSR *avoided* war (deterrence)	Indeterminate — predicts both
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions + interdependence raise war's cost	complex interdependence, institutions	EU ending Franco-German war; 1914 (failed)	Interdependence didn't stop 1914
Lib. internationalism	Regime type — democracies avoid war with each other	democratic peace, Kantian triangle	Western Europe post-45	Edge cases
Constructivism	Whether the rival is constructed as enemy or competitor	identity, "anarchy is what states make of it"	US–Canada (amity) vs US–USSR (enmity)	Hard to predict ex ante
Critical theory ⚠️	War/peace reflects material/class structures	class, world-systems	WWI imperial rivalry	Coarse; hard to test

11. Why do states pursue nuclear weapons?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Security under anarchy; deterrence vs a threat	self-help, deterrence, security dilemma	North Korea; Pakistan (vs India)	Can't explain restraint by capable states (Japan)
Lib. institutionalism	Regimes (NPT) raise costs → most *don't*	international regime, reciprocity	NPT near-universal membership	Explains non-pursuit better than pursuit
Lib. internationalism	Domestic politics/prestige coalitions	domestic preferences, the black box	India's domestic drivers	Needs a case-specific coalition
Constructivism	Prestige/identity ("a great power has the bomb"), or a taboo restrains	identity, norms	France's force de frappe; nuclear taboo	Competing identity claims cut both ways
Critical theory ⚠️	The order lets the core keep bombs, denies the periphery	hegemony, world-systems (core–periphery)	NPT haves vs have-nots	Doesn't explain *why* a given state builds

12. Why has great-power war declined since 1945?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Nuclear deterrence + bipolar stability	deterrence, polarity, balance of power	US–USSR Cold War peace (MAD)	Can't explain peace among non-nuclear democracies
Lib. institutionalism	Dense institutions + interdependence raise costs	complex interdependence, institutions	EU; Bretton Woods/WTO order	Didn't stop proxy wars
Lib. internationalism	Spread of democracy → democratic peace	democratic peace, Kantian triangle	post-45 Western Europe	Doesn't cover autocracies' restraint
Constructivism	A norm against great-power war took hold	norms, socialisation	WWI/WWII "never again"; war delegitimised	Hard to isolate the norm's effect
Critical theory	US hegemony imposed a stable (profitable) order	hegemony, world-systems	Bretton Woods; dollar order	Over-credits structure

13. Why do states sometimes act against their material interests?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	They don't, really — apparent losses serve power/security	relative gains, self-help	costly signalling; alliance commitments	Explains the behaviour away rather than *for* it
Lib. institutionalism	Short-term cost for long-term reciprocal gain	shadow of the future, reciprocity, absolute gains	sunk reputational costs; treaty compliance	Stretches "interest" to fit
Lib. internationalism	A domestic coalition's interest ≠ the "national" one	domestic preferences, the black box	tariffs hurting consumers; farm subsidies	Needs the coalition identified
Constructivism	Identity/norms override material calculation	identity, logic of appropriateness, norms	Germany's post-45 restraint; costly norm compliance	Hard to prove norms *caused* it
Critical theory	"National interest" masks a *class* interest being served	class, ideology/legitimation	austerity serving capital	Hard to falsify

14. Why do economic sanctions often fail?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Targets prioritise survival; rivals help them	self-help, balance of power	Russia post-2014/2022; North Korea	Under-weights when sanctions *do* work
Lib. institutionalism	Work only with multilateral coordination/monitoring	collective security, information/monitoring	UN vs unilateral sanctions; leaky regimes	Hard to sustain coordination
Lib. internationalism	The target's regime insulates elites from pain	domestic preferences, the black box	authoritarian resilience (Iran, NK)	Varies by regime
Constructivism	Sanctions can harden a besieged national identity	identity, norms	Iran; Russia's "fortress" narrative	Hard to measure
Critical theory	Sanctions reinforce core dominance; hurt the periphery's poor	world-systems (core–periphery), hegemony	sanctions' humanitarian toll	Doesn't explain *failure* vs success

15. Why do power transitions (rising powers) cause conflict?

Theory	Explanation	Concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	A riser unsettles the balance → security dilemma, war risk	power transition, balance of power, security dilemma	US–China today; rising Germany pre-1914	Many transitions *don't* end in war
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions can socialise a riser peacefully	institutions, complex interdependence	China into WTO; post-45 order	Riser may defect once strong
Lib. internationalism	Depends on the riser's regime type	democratic peace, domestic preferences	democratic vs autocratic risers	Hard to generalise
Constructivism	Conflict if the riser is constructed as a threatening "other"	identity, intersubjective meaning	US–China threat framing; UK→US peaceful transition	Why peaceful sometimes? identity under-determines
Critical theory	Transition = struggle over who controls the capitalist order	hegemony, world-systems	British→American hegemony; US–China	Coarse; hard to test

Quick picking guide

- **Security / war / weapons** (6, 10, 11, 12, 15) → **realism** strongest main, **constructivism** or **liberalism** as counter.
- **Cooperation / law / institutions** (1, 2, 5, 8) → **liberalism** main, **realism** or **critical** counter.
- **Identity / norms / "why against interest"** (4, 13) → **constructivism** main, **realism** counter.
- **Who-benefits / hierarchy** (3, 9) → **critical theory** makes a sharp counter; realism/constructivism as main.
- ⚠️ rows = the theory to attack in your rebuttal, not to defend as your main.